**Aquifer Open Study Notes**

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# Esther

## Esther 1:1

- The name Xerxes is the Greek version of the Persian Xshayarshan, which the Hebrew text calls 'akhash-werosh (Ahasuerus). His father, Darius I, who ruled from 521 to 486 BC, was king when Haggai and Zechariah urged the people of Judah to complete the temple in Jerusalem (see Ezra 4:24–6:22; Haggai 1:1; Zechariah 1:1).
- 127 provinces: Xerxes ruled a vast empire from India to Ethiopia.

## Esther 1:2

The fortress of Susa served as the king's winter capital during the colder months.

## Esther 1:4

- for a full 180 days: Officials likely took turns attending various events during this six-month period. This allowed them to maintain the nation's military and infrastructure.
- This grand display of pomp and splendor aimed to impress others with the king's greatness. It also shows Xerxes' pride.

## Esther 1:5

A second, shorter banquet let people from all social levels, from the highest to the lowest, see the king's great wealth. Due to the large crowd, this ongoing open-house event took place outside in the paved courtyard of the palace garden.

## Esther 1:6

White and blue (or violet) were colors of royalty. The mosaic pavement was also richly detailed.

## Esther 1:8

no limit was placed on the drinking: Often, guests would drink only when the Persian king offered a toast (see Xenophon, Cyropaedia 8.8.18). At this banquet, people could drink freely.

## Esther 1:9

Since Vashti means the best, desired, beloved, it might be a title for a favored wife rather than her real name. Ancient Greek historians call her Amestris (for example, Herodotus, Histories 7.114). Her son, Artaxerxes I, became king of Persia and ruled from 465 to 424 BC, after Xerxes died (see Ezra 4:7–23; 6:14; 7:1, 7, 11–26; 8:1; Nehemiah 1:1; 2:1; 5:14; 13:6).

## Esther 1:10

- the king's heart was merry with wine: He was likely quite drunk and might do something unwise.
- Eunuchs were servants who had been castrated. Their jobs often involved contact with the women of the royal harem.

## Esther 1:11

she was beautiful to behold: The king wanted to show off one of his prized possessions.

## Esther 1:12

- refused to come: The queen's refusal is not explained. Perhaps she feared the king, who was drunk, might humiliate her.
- the king became furious: His anger likely increased because he was drunk and felt embarrassed in front of his friends.

## Esther 1:13

The king did not react immediately. He consulted his wise advisers, as he usually did. He checked with Persian legal experts to see what could be done about his disobedient wife (Esther 1:15).

## Esther 1:15

According to law...what should be done: In his embarrassment, the king likely wanted to punish Vashti as much as possible.

## Esther 1:16–18

Queen Vashti has wronged: The adviser Memucan did not use Persian law to guide the king's decision. His hasty advice made Vashti's action seem like a possible crime for all women.

## Esther 1:17

all women, causing them to despise their husbands: The council's decision was driven by fear of consequences, not by facts or law.

## Esther 1:19

issue a royal decree...that it cannot be repealed: This decree would become an unchangeable law (Esther 8:8; Daniel 6:8, 12).

## Esther 1:22

- The decree was published in each region's script and language so everyone in the Persian Empire could understand it.
- every man should be master of his own household: In the ancient Near East, it was already common for men to rule their houses. The decree made this custom legally enforceable.

## Esther 2:6

He: King Jehoiachin was exiled in 597 BC (2 Kings 24:6–16), over 100 years earlier. It was likely one of Mordecai's ancestors who was taken into Babylonian captivity.

## Esther 2:7

Hadassah is a Hebrew name meaning myrtle. Esther is a Persian name meaning star.

## Esther 2:9

- provided her with beauty treatments and the special diet: Hegai knew the king's preferences and chose the best candidates for special attention.
- Hegai assigned seven of the best assistants to Esther, showing he believed she was a top candidate for becoming queen.

## Esther 2:10

Mordecai had likely faced some prejudice against Jews. Esther's Jewish heritage would later help her reveal Haman's terrible plan.

## Esther 2:12

The twelve months of preparation likely included learning court customs and beauty treatments. However, the main focus was on physical beauty.

## Esther 2:14

a second harem: Each woman spent one night with the king in his bedroom. After that, she lived like a widow unless the king remembered her name and called for her. The women in the second harem lived comfortably in a luxurious setting under the care of Shaashgaz, the king's eunuch.

## Esther 2:15

Hegai knew what the king liked, so he gave Esther good advice. She wisely accepted and followed it.

## Esther 2:17

he placed the royal crown upon her head: Now Esther had access to the king's heart as his favored wife. She was in a position where God could use her to influence the king's thoughts and actions.

## Esther 2:18

- he king held a great banquet, Esther's banquet: The king honored his wife instead of showing her off (compare Esther 1:11).
- He proclaimed a tax holiday: The Hebrew word for "public holiday" (hanakhah) is related to the verb meaning "rest" (nukh). The book describes how the Jewish people found rest from their enemies' threats (see Esther 9:16–22).

## Esther 2:19

- When the virgins were assembled a second time: Since the queen had been chosen, the rest of the woman would join the other concubines.
- Mordecai was sitting at the king's gate: Court cases and official business took place at the gate. There, Mordecai heard about the plot against the king (Esther 2:21–23).

## Esther 2:20

- still had not revealed her lineage or her people: The repetition of this point (see also Esther 2:10) shows its importance to the story.
- With humility, she continued to follow Mordecai's directions. She did not become proud or forget her people or the family that raised her.

## Esther 2:21

Bigthana might be the same person as Bigtha from Esther 1:10, one of the king's seven eunuchs. He and Teresh guarded the king's bedroom. They could have easily carried out their plan if they had not been discovered.

## Esther 2:22

- Queen Esther received the information. The fastest and safest way to inform the king was through her.
- Although Esther could have taken credit for the information to promote herself, she credited Mordecai for the report, which becomes important later in the story (Esther 6:1–3).

## Esther 2:23

- hanged on the gallows: Thought this phrase has often been translated as hanged on a gallows, inscriptions from ancient Persia show that impale-

ment was a common execution method. Xerxes' father, Darius I, claimed he impaled 3,000 Babylonians when he conquered Babylon. Sometimes, authorities executed criminals first and then displayed them on a stake, as with the execution of Haman's sons (Esther 9:5–14).
- This was all recorded, but Mordecai was not rewarded until much later (Esther 6:1–14).
- While various records of Xerxes' reign have been found, the specific book mentioned here no longer exists.

## Esther 3:1–15

Haman's hatred for Mordecai grows into a plan to kill all the Jewish people.

## Esther 3:2

People often bowed to those in higher positions (for example, Genesis 33:3). Mordecai worked at the palace's main gate, and Haman entered the king's court through this gate. This gave Mordecai many chances to disobey the king's order by not bowing to Haman.

## Esther 3:6

Haman did not care about justice; he wanted revenge. He was determined to do everything he could to destroy Mordecai, even if it meant wiping out all the Jews.

## Esther 3:7

the Pur (that is, the lot) was cast before: Throwing the Purim was like throwing dice. The Hebrews used lots to understand God's will (Leviticus 16:8–10; Nehemiah 10:34). Persian astrologers used purim in the first month of the year to find out which days would bring good fortune.

## Esther 3:8

- people scattered and dispersed: Jews marryied within their close communities and resisting integration into the larger culture.
- Their laws are different: They followed unique laws, including eating and religious customs, to remain separate from the sinful practices of surrounding people (Leviticus 14:42–45; 15:31; 19:2, 26–37).
- they do not obey the king's laws: This accusation is generally false and likely refers to Mordecai's refusal to bow to Haman.
- So it is not in the king's best interest to tolerate them: Haman exploited the king's fears and interests, similar to what Memucan did in Esther 1:16. Intolerance toward any group contradicted the Persian tendency to respect cultural and religious differences.

## Esther 3:9

Haman revealed his intentions by offering to bribe the king with a large amount of silver. This should have made the king suspicious of Haman's motives. The value of the proposed gift was so high that Haman may have exaggerated to show his intended generosity.

## Esther 3:10–11

- The king agreed without any investigation. He appears irresponsible and easily influenced. By removing his signet ring, the king gave up control over official policies. By giving it to Haman, he showed that Haman had full authority to seal the decree.
- the enemy of the Jews: The narrator's new title for Haman hints at his power to harm the Jews (see also Esther 8:1; 9:10, 24).
- Keep your money…These people are given to you to do: It seems the king did not want the bribe, but Genesis 4:7 suggests Haman did give the money. The king followed a common practice to make the bribe and his greed less obvious (compare Genesis 23:10–16). For public appearance, the king pretended not to care about the money, but he actually did.

## Esther 3:12

On the thirteenth day of the first month: Haman chose the day before the Jewish Passover (see Exodus 12:6) to scare and demoralize the Jews. However, just as during the Exodus, God would miraculously save the Jews from a tyrant trying to destroy them.

## Esther 3:13

- The phrase destroy, kill, and annihilate is repeated with irony in Esther 8:11 and 9:5.
- the thirteenth day of Adar, the twelfth month: Haman's "lucky day," chosen by casting lots (Esther 3:7), was eleven months after the decree. By God's plan, this gave time to overcome the decree.
- The property of the Jews would be given to those who killed them. Haman cleverly bribed the potential executioners.

## Esther 3:14–15

- This decree had the full authority of King Xerxes.
- The foolish king and wicked Haman celebrated, but the people of Susa were confused and upset by the unfair decree.

## Esther 4:1

Mordecai's intense reaction showed deep sorrow and mourning (see 2 Samuel 1:11; Ezra 9; Jonah 3:5–9).

## Esther 4:2

the law prohibited anyone…from entering that gate: The king did not want to hear sad stories or people asking for mercy.

## Esther 4:3

there was great mourning among the Jews: Although these reports of lamenting do not mention God's name, the lamenting and fasting suggest they were praying for God to intervene and save his people (Exodus 2:23–25; Ezra 9:5–15; Daniel 9:1–19).

## Esther 4:8

- A copy of the decree with the king's seal would show Esther how serious the situation was.
- implore his favor: Mordecai did not give Esther reasons to present to the king. He only asked her to appeal to the king's mercy and use her influence for her people.

## Esther 4:11

- who approaches the king in the inner court without being summoned—that he be put to death: The king's guards strictly controlled access to him to prevent unwanted guests from wasting his time with minor requests. These were the official court rules, so Esther faced great danger. She likely decided against asking for an audience through a messenger, possibly because she would have to explain her reasons.
- I have not been summoned to appear before the king for the past thirty days: Esther had no guarantee of his favorable response.

## Esther 4:13–14

- Do not imagine…you alone will escape: Mordecai did not back down or excuse her because of the danger. He reminded her that staying silent would be more dangerous.
- relief and deliverance for the Jews will arise from another place: Mordecai knew God's promises and understood that God would not allow his chosen people to be destroyed (see Genesis 12:3; 22:18; 28:14; Isaiah 60:1–5).
- perhaps you have come to the kingdom for such a time as this?: Esther's rise to power was not just luck. Her position as Xerxes' favored wife and queen was a role God gave her to influence history for the Jewish people.

## Esther 4:16

- fast for me: Esther was convinced, but she wanted as many Jews as possible to pray for God to save her life.
- Do not eat or drink for three days, night or day: A complete fast without any food or water usually lasted only one day (Leviticus 16:29–31; Judges 20:26). The three-day duration showed the seriousness of the situation and the urgent need for God's help.
- I will go to the king, even though it is against the law: Despite the danger, she decided she must act for her people's sake.
- And if I perish, I perish!: She, like Mordecai, was a person of character who would do what was right despite personal danger.

## Esther 5:2

The king extended the gold scepter in his hand toward Esther: She was not killed for entering the king's presence without an invitation (Esther 4:11, 16).

## Esther 5:3

Even up to half the kingdom, it will be given to you: This common saying meant the king would be generous with her request. The king wanted nothing to stop Esther from telling the whole truth.

## Esther 5:4

If it pleases the king: Esther showed proper respect (compare Esther 1:12).

## Esther 5:8

grant my petition…come tomorrow: It was customary not to seem eager when asking for a favor or negotiating an agreement. The delay gave Xerxes time to learn about Mordecai's loyalty, which helped stop Haman's plot (see Esther 6:1–14).

## Esther 5:9

Mordecai's fasting had ended, and he returned to his official duties at the gate. By not standing or trembling, he strongly refused to honor Haman (compare Esther 3:2–6).

## Esther 5:9–14

This short pause highlights how deeply Haman hates Mordecai.

## Esther 5:14

- A sharpened pole was a common execution device (see also Esther 2:23; Genesis 40:19, 22; Joshua 8:29).
- Seventy-five feet (fifty cubits) is very high, but Haman wanted to make an example of Mordecai, allowing everyone to see his body. The number might be an exaggeration for effect—fifty cubits is a round number—or it might mean a stake placed high on the city wall for public viewing.

## Esther 6:1

- sleep escaped the king: God was protecting Esther and Mordecai.
- the Book of Records, the Chronicles: Ancient kings kept records of their rule.

## Esther 6:2

Fortunately, the king's servant opened the royal records to the page where Mordecai revealed the plot (Esther 2:21–23).

## Esther 6:3

What honor or dignity has been bestowed on Mordecai for this act?: Persian kings were known for being generous to their supporters, so the king was likely surprised that nothing had been done.

## Esther 6:4–6

As the king thought about how to honor Mordecai, Haman came to request Mordecai's death. Ironically, the king asked Haman for advice on how to reward Mordecai.

## Esther 6:7–9

Haman loved public praise and recognition. He wanted to be honored like a king, to wear royal clothes, and to ride the king's horse. In short, he wanted to be king for a day. Haman believed another of the king's top officials would honor him through the streets of Susa. Instead, Haman had to honor Mordecai in that role (Esther 6:10).

## Esther 6:10–12

do just as you proposed...to Mordecai the Jew: Haman, completely shocked by this reversal, could only obey the king's command in full detail.

## Esther 6:13

Since Mordecai, before whom your downfall has begun, is Jewish, you will not prevail against him: Haman's wife and friends saw this as more than coincidences. The text does not explain why Zeresh and the advisers believed Mordecai's Jewish heritage would cause Haman's plans to fail.

## Esther 7:3–4

- my life...and the lives of my people: The statement that someone wanted to kill the queen and her family likely surprised and shocked the king.
- my people and I have been sold: Esther carefully mentioned the large sum Haman paid the king to approve the decree (Esther 3:8–11). She also used the exact words from Haman's decree, stating its purpose was to destroy, kill, and annihilate (see Esther 3:13).
- If we had merely been sold as menservants and maidservants, I would have remained silent: Esther humbly explained her request was due to the severe threat against her and her people.

## Esther 7:5

where is the one who would devise such a scheme?: The king could hardly believe what he heard and could not imagine someone attempting this terrible act. He did not ask for details about Esther's accusations, assuming they were all true (compare Esther 3:10).

## Esther 7:6–7

- Esther identified wicked Haman as the enemy.
- Haman stood in terror: The queen's accusation and the king's anger made Haman's fate clear.

## Esther 7:8

- Haman was falling on the couch where Esther was reclining: This was a major mistake because no one should touch the queen or be on the same couch with her.
- Would he actually assault the queen while I am in the palace?: This exaggerated rhetorical question suggests Haman has the worst possible motives.

## Esther 7:9

- He had it built for Mordecai: Harbona, one of the king's seven eunuchs (Esther 1:10), did not seem to be Haman's friend and already knew about Haman's plot.
- Hang him on it!: This major reversal of fortunes shows God's guiding hand. For more on impalement, see study note on Esther 2:23.

## Esther 8:1

Haman had promised the wealth of the Jews to those who would kill them (Esther 3:13). In contrast, King

Xerxes gave Haman's property, the enemy of the Jews, to Queen Esther.

### Esther 8:2

The signet ring Haman used to seal the decree to destroy the Jewish people (Esther 3:10) was now given to the Jewish person he most wanted to destroy.

### Esther 8:3

Esther likely thought the king would cancel Haman's decree immediately after Haman died, but that did not occur. This time, she was more determined to address Haman's plan against her people.

### Esther 8:5

- Esther asked for the unusual favor of reversing a law signed with the king's seal.
- the letters that the scheming Haman: Esther diplomatically avoided implying that the king was responsible for Haman's orders.

### Esther 8:8

According to Persian law, once something is written, it cannot be revoked (see Esther 1:19; Daniel 6:8, 12; compare Psalm 148:6). However, a new decree with the king's royal seal could provide different or competing instructions.

### Esther 8:9

on the twenty-third day of the third month: The process of writing and sending the new decree intentionally mirrors the account of sending the original decree in Esther 3:12.

### Esther 8:11

- The king's decree allowed the Jewish people to defend themselves and take the property of their attackers. This reversed the earlier decree in Esther 3:13.
- The phrase destroy, kill, and annihilate ironically repeats the words from Haman's original order (Esther 3:13; see also 9:5).

### Esther 8:12

the thirteenth day of the twelfth month: This date was almost a year after Haman's first decree was announced (Esther 3:12).

### Esther 8:13

The Hebrew word translated as avenge can also mean to establish justice. When civil government could not control all parties in a conflict, this law allowed those attacked to establish justice by addressing the wrongs done to them.

### Esther 8:15

Just as the city of Susa was in chaos after Haman's first decree (Esther 3:15), now everyone celebrated. They understood the unfairness of the first decree and the fairness of the new one.

### Esther 8:17

many of the people of the land themselves became Jews: They converted to Judaism.

### Esther 9:1

On the thirteenth day of the twelfth month: When the day came, many enemies of the Jews wanted to fulfill Haman's wishes.

### Esther 9:3–4

People saw that Mordecai was the leader, so they knew opposing him was unwise.

### Esther 9:5

put all their enemies to the sword: It was not an attack on defenseless people or a ruthless killing spree. Instead, it was a successful self-defense against their attackers. The phrase here echoes Haman's original decree (Esther 3:12).

### Esther 9:6

Most people in the fortress of Susa supported Mordecai. The Jews killed 500 men, likely including Haman's relatives and close supporters, in a small revolt.

### Esther 9:7–10

They killed these ten sons of Haman: Everything Haman had boasted about (Esther 5:11) was gone, including his ten sons.

### Esther 9:10

but they did not lay a hand on the plunder: Although taking plunder from attackers was allowed (Esther 8:11), the Jews did not want the tainted wealth of Haman's sons. Many years earlier, Abram had refused his share of the plunder from the king of Sodom (Genesis 14:21–23).

### Esther 9:12

If the king had been upset by the high numbers, he would not have allowed more fighting (Esther 9:14–

15). It is more likely that the king was surprised by how many people supported Haman and opposed Mordecai's new leadership. He was concerned about the empire's political stability.

### Esther 9:13

Esther might have known that some people in Susa who attacked Jews on the first day escaped. They could be planning more attacks to avenge Haman's death.

### Esther 9:14

So the king commanded that this be done. An edict was issued in Susa: The king did not want fighting groups in the palace planning to kill each other.

### Esther 9:15

Once again, the Jews chose the high moral ground and did not take any plunder from their enemies, even though it was legally allowed (Esther 8:11; 9:10).

### Esther 9:16

75,000 seems like a large number. The Old Greek translation mentions 15,000, and the Targum notes 10,107 men. The Hebrew word translated as thousands can also mean an extended family or lineage. So, it is possible that 75 extended families were killed.

### Esther 9:17

they rested, making it a day of feasting and joy: Although God is not mentioned, they likely thanked God for their rescue. This marked the start of a new festival, later called Purim (Esther 9:19–32).

### Esther 9:19

- The annual festival and holiday of Purim celebrates God's blessing of peace from their enemies (see Deuteronomy 25:19; Joshua 21:44; 1 Samuel 7:11–14). The narrator notes that the festival was celebrated up to that time. Now, more than 2,400 years later, Jewish people still celebrate it every year.
- The exchange of food gifts showed the people's unity and care for each other. It also helped spread joy during the festival.

### Esther 9:23–26

These verses summarize the events that lead to the Festival of Purim.

### Esther 9:26–28

This paragraph explains why Purim is an accepted Jewish festival, even though Moses did not authorize it with other festival days.

### Esther 9:29–32

The letter that Queen Esther wrote officially supported Mordecai's proposal (Esther 9:20–23).

### Esther 10:1–2

King Xerxes imposed heavy taxes on the provinces. These taxes funded the Persian government's high spending.

### Esther 10:2

The Book of the History of the Kings of Media and Persia was the official record of Persian royalty. Although many ancient Persian records still exist, we have not found any mention of Mordecai's greatness in the records discovered so far.

### Esther 10:3

Mordecai the Jew did not boast like Haman did (Esther 5:11–12). Instead, this righteous man always cared for others. He was rewarded with a high government position as prime minister and earned the respect of his people. He was very great among the Jews.